Background and Purpose of the Study

Background. Categorization is not merely the process of grouping objects based on visual similarity; rather, it is a cognitive process through which we understand objects as belonging to the same 'kind' based on meaning and context (Freedman et al., 2001). For example, although wavelengths of light vary continuously, we perceive them as belonging to discrete categories such as 'blue.' In this way, learning categories can influence not only how we label objects but also how we perceive them.

An ambiguous color located at the boundary between blue and green may appear more blue or greener depending on its categorization (Bae et al., 2014). Such phenomena have been observed not only for color but also for relatively simple stimuli, including orientation, size, and faces (Goldstone & Steyvers, 2001). Recent research has begun to examine whether these category effects extend to complex, multi-feature stimuli, such as everyday scenes (Groen et al., 2017). Previous studies using AI-generated imagery have shown that people perceive scenes differently depending on their learned categories (Son et al., 2024).

The present study aims to investigate whether categories learned in one context can influence perception in entirely different contexts. To this end, participants will perform tasks involving scene memory and similarity judgments. Through this process, the study seeks to determine whether categorization is merely a judgment strategy or whether it fundamentally alters our underlying perceptual representations.

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